

THE SMARTEST OS?

With the growing number of phones and operating systems (OSes) available, all vying to be the one in your pocket, is it possible to figure out which one's the smartest for you?

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If the kind of queries we receive from readers on a regular basis are any indicator, the plethora of choices in the smart phone market confuse most people. It's becoming increasingly harder to figure out which platform suits us best for our usage scenario. Also, given that all of these OSes and models are being targeted at the masses, is it even possible to get that perfect OS for you? Now we can't give out a hundred options for a hundred different demographics and usage cases, so we decided to look at some common but important tasks for phones these days, look at how the OSes handle things differently (if so), and what that means to you...

The focused approach isn't popular anymore – gone are the days when a BlackBerry was the only phone a business oriented individual would want, or a Sony Ericsson phone would be the choice for those interested in good cameras or music on-the-go, or the Nokia N-series trying to offer both... These days, almost every phone is aimed squarely at almost everyone, and all OSes are trying to do everything, which brings us back to our conundrum – so which is the best? So let's not waste any more time, and get straight into our evaluation:



iOS dialer interface vs the Android dialer interface

Hello!

Among the four platforms – Android, iOS, BlackBerry and Windows – we find Android's method to be the best of the lot. While it is fairly close between Android and iOS, the Android integration and correct switchovers between call logs and potential contacts you may wish to dial is smooth. With Android it could also be a manufacturer customisation, so we checked the same functionality across HTC and Sony phones. iOS, by far, has the best looking on-screen keypad, while BlackBerry depends on the physical QWERTY – its touchscreen phones also offer a well laid out calling interface. We were rather disappointed with Windows Phone, which adds an extra step of having to demand that the number-pad be shown.

Add a buddy

Adding a new contact to the phonebook is usually a task done in a hurry, and a critical aspect for those who use their phone as a phone. First up, Android. Despite different skins and customisation by different smartphone manufacturers, the essence of the process remains the same across Android phones. There are two ways to add a contact on the phone: head to Contacts/People and click the "+" sign there, or go to the phone app, then the complete contacts list, and then add a contact. If you have Google Sync set up on your account, you can also add a contact via the web browser and it'll be synced to the phone. There are also a lot of third-party widgets that can sit on the home screen with your favorite contacts for instant access. However, iOS is just simplicity personified. Tap the phone app, and you will see the number-pad pop up. You will see a key with a person and a "+" sign next to it. Voila! With BlackBerry, it

is fairly simple as well – punch in a number as though you are dialing it, and then press the options key. You will see the "add to contacts" option. Alternatively, go to the phonebook and do this from there. With Windows Phone 8, you have the People app that is essentially the phonebook. Open that, and you see a "+" sign at the bottom of that list. Tap that, and you get to add a contact from here. All platforms seem to have made this simple task as easy to execute as possible. However, iOS and Windows Phone are the most convenient and easy to get used to – even for those who are not very comfortable with technology as a whole. BlackBerry's process isn't very complicated either. However, Android loses out a bit because on most phones, the phonebook is not up front for people to access, and the process of going through the dialer to add a contact can be slightly cumbersome.

Say cheese!

The first thing we do during our smart-phone camera tests is check for a dedicated camera key. But this feature is not unique across smartphones, and we are not considering that here. What we are looking at is how quickly you can get to the camera app and click a picture. With Android, you can have an icon on any of the home-screens. Tap that, and you are straight into the camera. Within that interface, there is a one-tap option of switching between the photo and video modes. The snaps and videos show up in the gallery/album application. With iOS, the process is pretty much the



Android - Camera Interface and iPhone - camera interface